Antumbra

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30783455.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, Gen, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Juliet (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra)

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by Greenagoo

Summary

Catra's past still haunts her, and the Whispering Woods are astir with strange magic. Adora and friends try to help Catra navigate her tangled web of nightmares and trauma.

Notes

This story contains some pretty realistic scenes of parental abuse, probably similar to what some of you or someone you know may have faced. I wanted to show just how disturbing and traumatizing abuse can be, out of respect for the gravity of the subject. I also tried to depict how that trauma can affect a person's ability to form and maintain healthy, trusting relationships, and how even if you love someone, it can be difficult to know how to be there for them in a meaningful way, and that even the most will intentioned actions can have undesirable results.

This story is rather short by design, as it's the first thing I've really sat down to write in years.
Feel free to leave feedback/comments as I'd love to hear what you think.
Hope you enjoy!

Chapter 1

Chapter 1 - Umbra

Catra bolted upright with a shriek, her clothes twisted and drenched with sweat. She sat for a moment, disoriented, drawing breath rapidly. Slowly she remembered where she was. She sighed as she fell back into her pillow, her heart still racing. "Another dream, that's all," she muttered to herself.

She turned her head, to see Adora splayed out, snoring away. She had kicked her blanket down in her sleep and it was now tangled around her legs, a stream of drool running down her cheek and pooling on her pillow. Catra felt a pang of jealousy. How could she sleep so soundly? She groaned and pressed her fingers into her eyelids. Why couldn't she just let it go? Her life was so much better now and she had changed so much. Hadn't she? So why was she still haunted by her? Still seeing her lurking in the shadows. Still bearing the pain of being made to feel like she was nothing.

She sighed and lay motionless for a few seconds before admitting defeat. "Looks like another long night" she grumbled as she carefully slid out of bed. She grabbed her cloak as she stepped over a sleeping Melog, who perked their head up at the movement. "It's okay, I just need some fresh air" she reassured her familiar as she turned for the door. She didn't have to look to know that they were already up and determined to accompany her. She didn't protest. She quietly opened the door and turned to give another glance at a still snoring Adora, just in time to see her snort and roll over, her face now directly in her drool puddle. Catra shook her head and couldn't help but smirk. What a dummy. She stepped into the halls of the Brightmoon castle as the door clicked softly behind her.

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...

The morning moon crested the hill and the light shone through the balcony window, right into the face of a still slumbering Adora.

She groaned and began to stir. "Hnnngggg nooooo..." She grumbled weakly. "I don't wannaaaaaa..." She stretched out as far as she could manage, still trying to wake up fully. "Good morning furball" she said through a monster yawn. But when she turned, the bed next to her was empty. "Catra?"

She untangled herself from her bedding and rose to her feet, wiping the moisture from her face. "Guess I was -really- out." She pulled herself into her old uniform, tied her hair up in the usual ponytail, and gave herself a glance in the mirror. "Heyyy good lookin' ready to greet the day?" She quipped cheerfully, shooting finger guns at mirror Adora. She stepped out on to the balcony and took a deep breath. Staring out across the castle grounds, she was greeted with one of her favorite visions. The flourishing plant life was exceptionally lush since the magic had been restored to the whole planet. Adding a whole new level of beauty to an already awe inspiring view. She leaned against the railing and looked down into the garden, noticing a huddled form at the base of a large tree. She sighed as the joy inspired by the flora was replaced with feelings of sadness. "Oh Catra... Not again..."
...
She gave a solemn nod to the guards as they saluted her on her approach. Pushing open the large double doors, she stepped out into the castle courtyard. She wordlessly made her way past the flowerbeds and statues, toward the slumped form beneath the tree. She stopped next to Catra and stood silently for a moment. She never really knew what to say. Everytime she tried to pick comforting words, they sounded callous to her. She opted for silence, and instead just slid down the tree to sit next to Catra, who remained motionless. She placed a hand on her shoulder and gave a small squeeze, as if to say "I'm here."
Melog lay on the other side of Catra, awake, yet still.

After a short while, Catra turned her head slightly, peering at Adora from beneath her hood.
"Why can't I just forget? She's gone. Her words are nothing but wind now, but they still hurt as bad as the day she said them. I just want to forget."
Adora wrapped an arm around Catra's shoulders as Catra leaned

into her. She ran her fingers through Catra's hair. It was getting so long again. She had really missed it.
She remained silent, continuing to comfort her physically. Minutes passed. Unmoving, they stayed like that, Adora embracing her love beneath the tree. She peeked down to see Catra had fallen asleep, a soft purr rumbling from within.
Adora sighed and let her head rest against the tree, tears welling up in her eyes and beginning to stream down her cheeks as she cried silently. She had to do something, but what could she do? Emotional pain couldn't just be healed away with magic. She could heal the body, but not the soul. She needed help. Suddenly, an idea struck her. But it could wait. For a little longer at least. She smiled down at Catra, her tears glistening in the daylight. "It'll all be okay," she whispered, planting a gentle kiss on Catra's head, "I promise."
...
...
The doors to the throne room flew open suddenly with a loud bang. Micah, his sister Castaspella, and Glimmer, jumped at the sound.
"AHH! I'M SO SORRY!"
Adora loudly apologized.
They gave her a concerned look.
"Is everything alright Adora?" Castaspella inquired with a raised eyebrow.
"Yes Aunt Casta. I mean no. I mean mostly. There's no trouble, I just need help"
Castaspella had insisted that Adora call her Aunt, since she was family after all. She still wasn't sure exactly what that meant but she obliged nonetheless.
Glimmer and Micah exchanged looks before turning back to Adora.
"Adora... It's been over a year and there's still no sign of..."
"Nononono not that. Well kinda but no. Do you know where Entrapta is? I need her."
Adora said hurriedly.
Glimmer stepped forward and placed a hand on Adora's shoulder.
"Whoa whoa, just slow down. What's going on? I think she's out with George and Lance investigating a first ones ruin they

discovered last week on the far side of the valley of the lost."
Adora took a deep breath and slowly exhaled.
"It's... Catra. She needs help. Badly."
A sad, knowing expression crossed Glimmer's face.

Micah finally piped up.
"Anything you need, all of Brightmoon is at your disposal."
He nodded to Glimmer.
"It sounds like your friends need you. Your aunt and I can handle this minutiae just fine."
She nodded wordlessly and took Adora's hand, and with a blink and a sparkle, they vanished.
...
...
"Hey! Be careful with that!"
A shrill voice cautioned as the robot fumbled a newly discovered artifact. A flash of pink snatched the artifact mid air and gently set it on the nearby workbench.
The robot beeped apologetically.
"Oh, it's okay. I could never be mad at you!"
Entrapta embraced the robot in a hair hug as Lance rounded the corner. "Every find is more amazing than the last!"
Lance exclaimed as he held aloft a strange vessel covered in first ones writing. George looked up from his work at the table and burst into laughter.
"Ah yes, the wonders of the ancient chamber pot."
Lance gave a defensive sputter. "Hey! Every find is a valuable piece of history!"
George chuckled, "Yes dear, I suppose you're right. But how about I show you something a little more mysterious?"

"Ooh! What is it?" Lance queried excitedly as he rushed over to the bench.
"We're not really sure yet," Entrapta chimed, "but it's definitely a piece of tech. Very old. I'd guess it's probably from around the times that the first ones started settling Etheria. Much older than this ruin, in fact! It's so exciting!"
She gushed, waving her hands excitedly. But before she could go full geek mode, there was a pop and a flash, and suddenly

glimmer and Adora were inches from her face.
"Ahh!" She exclaimed as she fell backwards, being caught by a helper bot.
"Oh! It's you! Hi!" She greeted them.
Adora waved with a smile.
"What brings you clear out here?" George asked the girls.
"Oh, hi Bow's dads! Nice to see you again. We're actually here for Entrapta."
"Oh, I see, well don't let us distract you, we're just inventorying some of these discoveries. We've barely scratched the surface. Getting the sand out of everything is the most time consuming part. Being as the place was buried in the desert for hundreds of years, it's to be expected I suppose. We never would have found it if not for that storm uncovering it. But I digress, we'll leave you to your business."

And with that, George and Lance headed back into the deeper parts of the ruins. "A chamber pot!" He could be heard laughing as they rounded the corner.
The girls turned back to Entrapta, who had resumed her tinkering at the workbench, her tongue poking out of the corner of her mouth.
"Aha! I see! Maybe if I..."
Adora cleared her throat to secure her attention.
"Huh? Oh yeah, right."
She carefully placed the tech back on the table and turned to face her friends.
"So... What do you need my help with?" She asked as she wiped her hands on her pants, ignoring the robot offering her a rag.
Adora took a deep breath before launching into her plan. "Okay so I have an idea..."
...
...
"Hey wildcat! Wait up!"
Scorpia ran up to Catra, stopping to catch her breath.
"Hey, Scorpia. What brings you to Brightmoon?"
Scorpia regained her composure. She was wearing long baggy shorts and a muscle shirt. Appropriate for the warmer weather. A

small flower was pinned to her hair behind her left ear.
"There's an alliance meeting today but we're missing a few people. Have you seen Adora at least? We need her for ice ball."
The princess alliance wasn't really necessary since global peace had been instilled, but they still used it as an excuse to spend time together nonetheless.
"Not since this morning. She said
something about tech and ran off to find Glimmer."
"Aww dangit! Wellllll... Maybe you'd like to play?" Scorpia pleaded, putting on her trademark cutesy face.
"Not today Scorps, I'm not really feeling up to socializing, let alone strenuous activity." Catra said, looking down as she crossed an arm to hold her other arm.
Scorpia's pleading turned to concern.
"Everything okay kitty kat?"
Catra turned away, "yeah... I'm just... Working through some stuff. It's fine."
Scorpia gingerly placed a pincer on Catra's shoulder. "You know I'm here for you. You're my best friend."
Catra spared her a weak smile. "Thank you Scorpia, you're a good friend. I'll come by later, I promise." Scorpia watched her walk away, down the hall and around the corner. The look of concern remained on her face. "Am I really a good friend if I can't even help you? I wish I could do more. I'm sorry wildcat..." She sullenly turned to head back to the group.
...
Catra wandered the halls and grounds for what felt like hours, eventually looking up to find herself at the edge of the whispering woods. She paused. All her meditation and therapy sessions with Perfuma had helped her overcome her crippling guilt about her actions in the Horde, and they'd made good progress with her abandonment issues, but she still hadn't opened up fully. She didn't know if she was ready to face that part of her past head on yet, but she had to do something. She stepped into the woods, Melog at her side.
...
...
Micah and Castaspella emerged from the conference room with a

groan. The war may be long over, but the politics never ended. The king turned to his sister, about to suggest they get something to eat, when they were approached hastily by General Juliet. "My Liege, we've found something. It might be... Her." The siblings tensed up and shared a look. "Are you certain? We must be sure before we tell the others." The general removed her helmet, "one of our scouts saw something in the woods, though they couldn't confirm for sure. I've dispatched a squadron to search the area thoroughly and ordered hourly reports." Micah shook his head. "I'll go myself. I need to be there in case they find her." He turned to his sister. "You know, of course I'm coming." She said before he could even ask. He placed a hand on her shoulder and nodded, turning back to the General. "Okay, let's leave immediately." Lunch would have to wait.

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Catra navigated the foliage with surprising ease. Despite being unfamiliar with the woods due to not spending much time there since the war ended, it was almost as if the trees and shrubs were making way for her, as if guiding her. She had no idea where she was going, she simply kept walking. Not even concerned with finding her way back. Something seemed to be calling to her, as if she needed to be somewhere. Suddenly she felt a tug on her cloak and cried out in surprise. As she reflexively pulled away, she tripped over a root and fell backwards. Too late she saw the steep slope. She yelled out as she tumbled and slid down the muddy terrain. Finally coming to a stop against a large fallen tree.

"Ouch. That hurt real bad." She said sarcastically to herself. She righted herself and picked the debris from her hair and clothes. Great. If she wasn't lost before, she definitely was now. She glanced around, finding herself at the edge of a small clearing, but it was eerily quiet.

"Must you make such a racket?" Came a voice from her right. She jumped back in surprise and hissed. From the other side of a rather large, faintly glowing bush, Hordak emerged. Though he resembled his former self in body only. His attire no longer horde armor or one of Prime's haunting uniforms. Instead, he was

dressed in a simple flaxen robe, a rope sash around his middle with several small leather pouches adorning it. A sturdy wool cloak draped about his shoulders, and everything bearing many small frays, rips, burns, and stains. A small pink pendant dangled loosely from a thin silver chain around his neck. He never looked up from what he was occupied with on his tablet.

Catra relaxed slightly, but remained cautious.
"What are -you- doing way out here?" She shot out, a little more hostile than she had intended.
"I could ask the same of you." He retorted. Catra stood, staring blankly at him for a few beats, but as she opened her mouth to speak, he beat her to it.
"I've been studying the magic in this part of the woods. There's been some strange activity the past few days. Well, stranger than normal for the whispering woods. I intend to discover the source and determine if it's a danger to anyone. It may simply be degraded tech causing magical interference. At least, that was Entrapta's theory. But alas, she's not here, so I must rely on... Other sources of expertise."
"Other sources? Who-"

" Ahhh! There's you are! And there YOU are dearie!"
A small hunched figure came shuffling through the bushes to Catra's left. An ancient looking, yet surprisingly spry old woman, her hair a wild mess. Her many bangles clinking as she marched across the clearing, basket in hand.
"Ahh madam Razz, just in time." Hordak beamed with a smile as he gently took the basket from her. Catra felt her jaw drop.
"You two know each other?"
Catra had never actually met Razz, but she had heard much about her from the others. Seeing her in person was surreal, however. What a strange old woman. The butterflies hovering around her were exceptionally bizarre.
Razz cackled, "Oh yes dearie. We've been friends a long long time. Though he wasn't very nice for a while." Hordak grunted, addressing Catra's puzzled look.
"I feel she's being truthful, yet I have only known her for several months. I've grown rather fond of her however. She knows more

about magic than anyone I've ever encountered. Probably more than any on Etheria. And she possesses strange powers that I have yet to comprehend. She is a most curious friend indeed."

"Oh hush hush, this isn't about me." She waved dismissively at Hordak. "This is about our friend Catra here." She said, turning to face the increasingly perplexed Catra.
"Me? And how do you know my name? Did Adora tell you about me?"
"So forgetful child. Do you not remember? Anyway it doesn't matter, you're here now, but not yet where you need to be."
Catra felt her face grow hot. "You're not making any sense. Remember what? Be where?" She looked to Hordak as if expecting an answer. He simply shrugged. "If she was expecting you, then it was only a matter of time before you came. That you can be assured of. Like I said, she possesses strange, unfathomable abilities."

Catra stood at a loss for words.
"So, your turn, what brings you out this far, Catra?" Hordak queried.
"It's Shadow Weaver!" She blurted out, before covering her mouth with her hand.
"Shadow Weaver?" He scowled. "What about her?" He probed.
Suddenly, it all came spilling out. The sleepless nights, the words echoing in her head over and over and over. The intrusive thoughts, visions of Shadow Weaver being consumed by the inferno, all the painful memories and the self loathing that she felt every day in the Horde. Being told she was worthless. Being struck and choked and thrown around. All of it. And the entire time, all she could think was "why am I telling this to -him-? Why to him and this stranger? Why can't I talk to my friends like this? What's wrong with me?"
Hordak and Razz listened in unflinching silence.

Finally, Catra fell to her knees, her voice hoarse from the outburst, tears streaming down her face as she sobbed quietly. Hordak approached her and silently offered a hand. She took it after a moment and allowed him to help her to her feet.

"Catra, I can not speak to the actions of that wretch. She wronged us both, and in the end, perhaps, she got what she deserved."
Catra let out another choked sob.
"She was under your command!"
"Oh come now, you can't be that naive to think I was ever able to control her. She did what she pleased, surely you know that."
Catra let out a weak laugh, "Boy, you're right about that." Another heaving sob escaped her.
"But she saved me! She saved Etheria! And I hate her for making me feel sorry for her!"
Hordak grunted, "She did not save Etheria, you and She-Ra stopped my... Stopped Prime. She made her own choice, as she always had before. And now it is up to you to make your own choices, as you always have."

Catra sniffled, wiping away her tears.
"And Catra, for what it's worth, which may not be much coming from me, but I regret the things I did to you. To Etheria. I've come to realize the beauty of this planet, and the quiet calmness of nature. There's so many regrets. I've..." He glanced at Razz who was busy digging in her basket. "I've been walking a difficult path, I've had to ask myself what I want in life."
He clutched the pendant around his neck. "What kind of person I want to be."

He extended a hand to Catra. "It's impossible to forget the past, but all those experiences shape us, and it's up to us to decide what we do with the wisdom we gain from the roads we walk."
Catra took Hordak's hand and gave it a squeeze. "Wow, that was really deep coming from you, old man." She managed a smirk. "You know, you were the only person above me who ever validated me, who actually acknowledged my efforts. Shadow Weaver never told me 'nice work' or 'good job' but you treated me as an equal, for a moment anyway."
She shook her head with a chuckle. "Man, we were terrible people huh? We did some fucked up shit to each other didn't- OW, HEY!"

"Language! Naughty child!" Madam Razz scolded as she bopped Catra on the head with her broom.
"Where did that broom even come from!" Catra yelled, rubbing her head.
"No time no time, you have places to be child, bring your friend with you." As if on cue, Melog emerged from the bushes, finally catching up to Catra. "Ahh see, I took the shortcut" she joked, giving Melog a pat on the head.
"So where exactly am I supposed to be in such a hurry?" She asked, pulling her hood back over her head.
"Come, come, I will lead you, but we must hurry." Catra made to follow Razz, but stopped to turn to Hordak. "Thank you, Hordak. I hope you find what you're looking for. Out here, and within yourself."
Hordak grunted and resumed looking at his tablet. "Yes yes, you as well..." He mumbled, already distracted.
Catra felt a small sense of relief, as if one if the many weights pinning her down had been lifted. If Hordak could change so drastically, then maybe... She turned and delved back into the woods with her new guide, and Melog at her side.
...
...
"So what do you think? Can you make it work?" Adora asked excitedly. Entrapta answered with the same energy. "I don't know, but I'm sure gonna try! I've never attempted something on such a scale! It's really very exciting!" She placed her hands and face against the towering walls of the Crystal Castle, "I'm gonna get to know you very well." She cooed, as if addressing an intimate friend.
Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Are you sure this is safe? You remember what this place is capable of, right?"
Adora scoffed, "It'll be fine. Besides, Light Hope was the real danger here, and I'm pretty sure her programming is gone now."

Glimmer frowned, "I trust you, I'm just worried what might happen."
Entrapta popped up between the two. "But imagine the good it could do! There's tech in there that I've only dreamed of tinkering

with! If I can figure out how it works, we could manipulate it to do whatever we want!"
"Yeah, the tech, that's what I'm afraid of. Does it even still work anyway? This place has been dark since you drained the heart."
Entrapta pulled out her tablet and began typing away furiously. "Yeah... The tech is pretty degraded, more than it already was. Without the heart powering it, it's hard to tell how far we'll get. We'll need an alternative power source most likely. Though they must have had something. After all, some of the other ruins still have power..."

Glimmer attempted to interject but Entrapta cut her off. "OH OH! I have a theory! Can you take me back to the ruins I was at earlier? I need to grab a few things!"
Glimmer groaned and grabbed her hand. "Fine, let's just get started."
Adora smiled at her, "Thank you Glimmer. For Catra."
Her smile was met in kind, "Yeah I know, for Catra." She said before vanishing with a pop, taking Entrapta with her.
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...
Micah and Castaspella followed General Juliet through the thick brush, pushing aside the vines and branches.
"It's just ahead." The general informed as they crested a hill, overlooking a small camp. They encountered a guard as they approached, and the general instructed her to fetch the scout.
"Come my liege, we can rest in my tent while we wait. She held open the flap, allowing them to enter first before following into her quarters. A humble sight lie before them. Furnishings were sparse. Only a bed and several plain chairs were present, while the bulk of the space was occupied by a large table, strewn with various maps and documents. The general pulled aside two chairs and beckoned the pair to sit, while she opted to remain standing.

They waited in silence, not even a minute passing before a young soldier stepped through the tent flap and saluted the general. His eyes grew wide seeing the King and his sister and he abruptly took a knee.
"Y-your grace! I did not expect you. Please, forgive my rudeness."

Micah laughed, "Oh there's no need for all of that now, there's more pressing matters."

The soldier was young, barely of qualifying age to serve. He was clearly nervous. He was clad in the low ranking uniform of the Brightmoon army. His helmet tucked under his arm.
"Stand, and tell us exactly what happened."
The soldier arose and stammered as he recounted his patrol from that morning. "... And that's when I saw a flash of scarlet, gone as suddenly as it was there."
Micah frowned. There wasn't much to go on, but the boy seemed certain of what he had seen, so it needed to be investigated further.
"Thank you son, you may take your leave."
The soldier bowed and turned to salute the general before turning on his heel and exiting the tent.

"Well, I'll go out to where this sighting happened. Casta, you stay here and question some more of the guards, see if you can learn anything else."
Castaspella nodded in agreement. "Just send up a signal if you need help."
She hugged her brother before departing. Micah turned to the general, "D ouble the patrols and inform my sister if anything happens. I'll return shortly with my findings."
The general nodded and saluted as the King headed out of her tent and off into the woods.
...
Hordak turned his attention to his tablet, which had begun beeping feverishly.
"Hmmm? What's this?"
It was a magical energy signature. One that he had never seen before, but one also strangely familiar. He jerked his head towards a sudden rustling of the bushes near him.
"Who goes there!' He demanded. Suddenly, a familiar figure burst from the brush.

"Ahh, King Micah, to what do I owe the pleasure?"
The king nodded curtly.

"I think you already know. The fact that I've run into you out here of all places would seem to indicate that we're after the same thing."
"In fact, I don't know, but you may be right. Perhaps if we combine our efforts, we'll find some common ground."
Micah hesitated.
"Oh come now, don't let our past nastiness get in the way. I'm a changed man after all." He said, motioning to his attire." Micah relaxed his stance slightly and grunted.
"I suppose you're right, and this is far too important for petty grudges. Why don't you tell me what you know first, and maybe I can fill in some of the blanks."
"I've been studying anomalous magical activity in this area. The local hermit has been assisting me in making sense of most of it. As it is, most of it can be explained as Etheria just being Etheria. That is, strange and ever changing. However, as luck would have it, right before you arrived, I found this."
He handed over his tablet.
"Do you recognize it?"
Micah tightened his grip on the tablet. "Impossible! But... Something's off.."
Hordak took the tablet back. "Yes, I noticed that as well. Upon further examination, it's definitely... Her."
"Shadow Weaver..." Micah grumbled under his breath.
"Yet I can't quite explain the differences it's showing. I need my partner, she might have more to say about it."
Micah nodded. "Well, let's not waste any time then, eh?"

As they set off, Micah shot Hordak a quizzical look. "So, how did you manage to not be discovered by all the patrols in the area? I was told that a special squadron had been dispatched to this very area."
"Give me some credit, I simply wished to remain undisturbed. It's not like I was hiding anything. But your soldiers are so noisy, and their intrusion would only hinder my research. So I used a refractory light field to obfuscate my work area. Magic and technology aren't so different when you get down to it."
Micah nodded in acceptance. He wouldn't pretend to know what

he meant by that. He understood magic, but technology had, for the most part, escaped his grasp of understanding.
They walked in silence for some time before coming upon a small obelisk. "We're here." Hordak said, approaching the structure. He pulled the pendant up and over his head and touched it to the stone, which began to glow and hum faintly.
"What are you doing?"
"These were something I uncovered in my travels. They can be found in various places around Etheria. They were once upon a time, used by the first ones for long distance communication. Entrapta and I retrofitted them so that we can send rudimentary signals to each other. It's crude, but it serves its purpose."
"Why not just contact her on your tablet?"
"This is more secure and subtle. Never know who might be listening."
"So you do have secrets then."
"Don't we all?"
With a smirk he replaced the pendant around his neck.
"Well, now what?"
"All we can do is wait."

(End chapter 1)

Penumbra

Chapter Summary

> The Crystal Castle is alive once more, but darkness stirs within. Will Catra be able to face her nightmarish past, or be consumed by the darkness?

Chapter 2 - Penumbra

Entrapta studied the strange tech closely,. It would appear her theories were correct. Her eyes lit up. Yes, this would more than suffice. Glimmer paced uncomfortably, not sure what use she could be. Adora was lying prone, picking at the grass, when she suddenly bolted upright.
"So how's it going? Did you figure it out.?" Entrapta tappa tapped away at her tablet a moment longer before disconnecting it from the artifact. She smiled triumphantly.
"Yes! It turns out I was right, this is an ancient power source. But there's a bit more to it than-"
Adora cut her off.
"Great! How soon can you have it up and running?"
Entrapta pondered briefly.
"Maybe an hour to get the juice flowing, but it'll be a few days to get everything changed to bypass the security systems, reconfigure the old hologram programming, get the safety protocols up and running, and push through a few firmware updates. No to mention the wiring issues..."
"Alright let's do it"
Entrapta giggled, "This is gonna be so fun!" She squealed as she set out to integrate the new tech. The first order of business was to get the place powered up so they could access the interior. She never noticed her pendant glowing.
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...
Hordak began to grow impatient, focused on his tablet. Could it

really be her? What would he say? What would he do? He couldn't say he particularly enjoyed the idea of seeing his lieutenant again. Micah leaned against a rock, arms crossed, his thoughts lingering in the same vein as Hordak's.
The idea of encountering his old mentor turned enemy brought to the surface many conflicting emotions. How many people had she hurt? He wasn't sure he could ever really forgive her. The entire time they were searching for her, it was only at the request of Adora. He had secretly hoped they would never find anything. It was easier just believing she was dead.

Hordak groaned, "it's been too long, let's just move. I can track her location."
He made a few taps on his tablet. "Oh... As luck would have it, she's not far. That's unexpected."
Micah stood and dusted himself off. "Well why didn't you say so? We've wasted enough time. Which way?"
Hordak motioned and began walking. What was she doing out here? Had she already discovered what they were after? He hastened his step, determined to find answers. The sky slowly grew darker.
...
...
"Got it!"
Came the victorious cry from Entrapta, followed by a brilliant display of glowing light shooting up the castle walls, the glow setting the clearing awash in an awe inspiring radiance.
Not a moment too soon either, as the daylight slowly began to fade as the brightest of the moons in the sky began to descend beyond the tops of the trees, darkening the woods around them. The warm glow of the Crystal Castle casting dancing shadows, like ethereal beings watching from the tree lines. Entrapta lifted her mask and wiped the sweat from her brow. The castle was finally powered, and oddly, it seemed stronger than before, as if supercharged.
"Well I think you can call it a day if you like, I'm just going to wrap up a few things before dinner time."
Glimmer suddenly snapped out of her bored state. "Oh! Oh no! I

was supposed to meet Bow an hour ago! Oh dammit! Adora, are you coming?"
Adora yawned, stretching her arms. "Naw it's okay, you go ahead. I'm gonna stay and help finish up here."
Glimmer hugged her friends goodbye. "Okay, I'll see you when you get home. Please be careful!" She pleaded.
"Always am." Teased Adora with a wink. Glimmer groaned as she vanished with a flash of light and sparkles. No sooner than she was gone, there came the sound of a twig snapping from the darkness of the tree line. Adora tensed up and called into the shadows, "who's there! Show yourself!" Her call was met with a yelp and a thud as Catra came stumbling through the brush, landing hard at the edge of the clearing. "Catra!" Came the call from Adora as she sprinted to help the haggard looking feline.
"What on Etheria are you doing way out here?" She demanded, as she took Catra's hand and hauled her up to her feet. Catra moaned as she brushed herself off briefly before giving up. Her hair was a tangled mess, her cloak sporting several large new tears. "Not a bad question. I ran into..." She looked behind her and then threw her head back in an agitated groan.
"How does she keep doing that?!" Razz was nowhere to be seen. She had been good at losing Catra multiple times on the journey here.
Adora looked puzzled.
"You lost me."
Catra shook her head.
"Doesn't matter. I'm here now. Question is, what are YOU two doing out here?" She nodded in the direction of Entrapta, and finally noticed the glowing spire. "Oh wowwww..." Her mouth fell agape for a moment at the stunning beauty, before she shook her head and refocused her attention on Adora.

Adora averted her gaze nervously. "Well, it was supposed to be a surprise. Well kinda. I was gonna talk to you about it first I swear. I just wanted to make sure it would actually work first."
"Make sure, what, would work, exactly"
"Weeeeellllllll... I kinda thought we could get the Castle holograms working again and maybe, if we could whip up a hologram of...

Shadow Weaver... Maybe you could face her and get some closure, in a safe environment."
She pointed her head down and peered up, tapping her index fingers together. Catra blinked several times before a scowl crossed her face.
"Wha- why would you think that was a good idea? Why would I want to see her?! She already haunts me constantly! How could you possibly think this would be a good thing?!"
Adora looked hurt, "I just felt like I needed to do something Catra! You're not sleeping, you're barely eating. I'm worried about you! Everyone is worried about you! Why can't you just try? We're trying to help you! We love you and we want you to get better!"
Catra scoffed and pushed past Adora. "You just don't get it, do you? You never did. But of course not! You were always her favorite! She never treated you the way she treated me! You saw what she did to me, the things she said! Imagine what she did when you weren't around to stop her!" Catra screamed, casting her ruined cloak to the ground.
"Oh you think she was kind to me?" Adora shot back. "She never loved me! She only saw me as a tool, a weapon she could use to fuel her messed up power trips! She didn't even see me as a person!"
Catra laughed, "Oh yeah I'm sure it was so hard for you to be encouraged and praised constantly!"
"'Uhhh, guys?" Entrapta said meekly, her tablet beeping frantically.

"You can't even imagine the pressure I was under constantly! Any small mistake I made was criticized tenfold! Everyone always jokes that I can't relax to save my life, but that's because I never learned how! If I wasn't trying to keep up my standing with her, I was always having to look after you!"
Catra stepped back defensively, "Oh, so it's my fault then?" Her expression changed briefly from anger to hurt, and quickly back to anger.
"No! Catra that's not what I-"
"Pfft whatever Adora, I'm sorry I was such a burden to you!"
"Guys! Something's very wrong!" Entrapta called. "Oh no oh nononono!"

The Crystal Castle rapidly began to shift from the usual opalescent glow, to a dark purple. Entrapta beelined for the newly installed power source in an attempt to disconnect it, but was thrown aside by a sudden energy surge. Catra and Adora were too wrapped up in their heated argument to even notice. "Catra no! I love you! Please don't be like this!"
"And what exactly -should- I be, Adora? Everyone always tells me how I should feel, but nobody understands what she did to me!"
"Catra! Let me help you! We can figure this out!"
The ground beneath Catra began to glow purple.
"I never asked for your help, and clearly I was right, because if this was your idea of helping, then I guess you really don't know me at all!"
Adora noticed the glow under Catra getting brighter.
"Catra!"
She called in an attempt to secure her attention to the matter.
"Forget it! Why can't you just, Leave. Me. ALONE!"
Upon her shouting that final word, the ground opened into a magical portal, engulfing Catra in an instant. Adora scrambled, attempting to reach the portal, but as quickly as it had opened, it shank and vanished.
"CATRA! NO!"
Adora clawed frantically at the ground where Catra had been standing, tears streaming to the ground as she sobbed heavily.
"CATRA! COME BACK!"

Entrapta finally came to, and saw Adora on her hands and knees, still clawing at the dirt calling Catra's name. She stood and stared, the whole scene made surreal by the bright purple glow of the spire. She slowly began to make her way to Adora, her ears still ringing from the pulse, her vision still slightly blurry, but wait, that was from the tears in her eyes, she determined. She stopped near where she had been working. Tinnitus? No! Her tablet was still sounding out in alarm. She reached out for it, but paused. No... Could it be...?

She sprinted to Adora. "We have company!" She gestured at the tree line, but Adora remained huddled over, the tears still flowing, but her sobs quieter now. Suddenly, from the forest, Hordak and

Micah burst forth at a run.
"HORDAK!"
Entrapta ran to meet them halfway and lept into his arms. They embraced for a short moment before they all turned their gaze to the Castle. Hordak's tablet was beeping wildly in his hand.
"It would appear, that we were too late." He said matter-of-factly.
Micah noticed the huddled Adora and immediately ran to her side.
"Are you okay?! What happened? Adora!"
Adora just shook her head, only managing to choke out the word "Catra" before she collapsed, sobbing, into Micah's arms.
He held her in silence, cradling her head as she wept.
Hordak looked to Entrapta. "What happened here? What are you even doing here?"
Entrapta looked at her feet. Catra... She was... Taken. There's something wrong with the tech we used to power the castle."
Hordak frowned. "We'll find her. But we have no time to spare. I need your help to analyze what's happening." Entrapta's eyes met his.
"I'm with you, Lab Partner."
Their matching pendants glowed in proximity to one another.
Together they hurried over to where Entrapta had been working and began tinkering with various pieces of equipment.
Adora wept silently in Micah's arms.
The tower casting its eerie glow upon them.
...
...
Catra's eyes quickly adjusted to the darkness. The only light was a faing purple glow that seemed to come from everywhere, but had no discernable source. What the hell had just happened? Where was she? "Adora!" She called out into the void. "Entrapta!?"
Silence.
"Anyone...?" She muttered quietly.
She stood as still as stone for a solid minute before risking a single step. An ear piercing shriek filled the air. She covered her ears with her hands. "Stop!" She yelled.
Silence.
"Adora, where are you?"
She spoke shakily, suddenly remembering their fight. Her stomach

twisted into a knot. Why did she say those things to Adora? She was only trying to help. She had to know she didn't mean it, right? She shuddered. What if those were the last words she ever said to her? She shook her head. No. She was going to make it through this. They're probably coming for her right now, wherever she was. She took another step. No loud noise this time.

She took another step. And another.
Suddenly the purple light greatly intensified, revealing that she was in a long hallway. It seemed to stretch on to eternity, but that was impossible, it had to end somewhere. She began the impossibly long walk, replaying the argument in her head.
"Stupid! I'm such an idiot!"
Suddenly a flash of color caught her peripheral vision. Scarlet. Her heart skipped a beat. She slowly turned her head, only to see a door. A door that wasn't there a second ago. She cautiously extended her hand, slowly wrapping her fingers around the knob. She turned, hearing the click as the mechanism disengaged. She paused and inhaled deeply, her heart was beating out of her chest. With a burst of courage, she flung the door open. It was her old room. Her Horde quarters. But it was empty. Why was this here? Where -was- here?
She approached her old bed, tracing her fingers across it. Her mind wandered to memories of the nights her and Adora sat up under the covers, sharing secrets and giggling for hours before falling asleep in each other's arms. "Catra!" The hair on the back of her neck stood up. There was no mistaking that voice. She wheeled around to see... Nothing.
"Get it together Catra."
She said to herself, making to exit the room. As she approached the threshold, she could swear she heard quiet whimpering. She ignored it and stepped back into the hallway. A different hallway. A Horde hallway. Was she losing it? She knew she wasn't really in the fright zone, but it sure felt real. She heard laughter and the slapping of shoes running. The noise passed right by her, but accompanied by nothing she could see.
"Man, you are S-L-O-W!"

That was her voice. A younger version of her, but her nonetheless. She walked in the same direction the voices had gone.

Suddenly, with a flash, everything changed. She was in the bathroom. She saw a form crying at the sink. It was her. She swallowed. She remembered this day. She had just lost to Adora in an important training evaluation. She had acted aloof about it, but in reality, she had given it her all. She would never admit it to her team, but she had wanted to win. Badly. Maybe if she could finally prove she was worth something, she would finally be acknowledged as more than a worthless parasite.
She reached out towards the shuddering form, but before her fingers made contact, it vanished. Her hand lingered midair, fingers slowly closing on air, before letting her arm slump back to her side.

Flash everything changed again.
She was in the locker room. She saw herself dressing down from training, the rest of her team joking and laughing off to the side as they did the same. She watched herself as she slipped back into her standard uniform. She felt like she looked so much younger. Of course though, this was a lifetime ago.
"Leave us."
Came a velvety yet terrifying voice. She felt goosebumps. A shadowy form blocked the doorway. She couldn't make it out, but she knew who it was. The other cadets hurriedly collected their things and slipped past the form. Past Adora pausing to shoot past Catra a worried look before departing.
Past Catra didn't acknowledge the figure, continuing what she was doing.
"Catra, despite my best efforts, you continue to disappoint me. Have you not suffered enough from your lack of enthusiasm?"
Past Catra slammed her locker shut, but did not turn around, remaining still and silent.
"Even now you defy me. After everything I've done for you, raised you, trained you, educated you, you show zero appreciation. You are dragging the rest of your team down to your level. Why even show up to training if you refuse to apply yourself?"

Past Catra looked at the ground, but still said nothing. "Absolutely pathetic. I grow tired of wasting my time on you." Past Catra wheeled around. "Then why do you!?"
She shouted. The form descended upon past Catra in an instant, pinning her to the locker by her throat, her other hand squeezing past Catra's face tightly.
"I find myself asking the same question, cadet."
The last word being spat like venom. "If you're of no use to me or your team, then why should you be allowed to stay? Why should you be allowed to exist?"
The grip on her throat tightened, the other hand moving to conjure a small, glowing black orb.
"Maybe everyone would be better off if you just... Disappeared."
She clenched her fist, extinguishing the orb, before throwing past Catra to the ground violently.
"You -will- get your act together, because the next time we need to have this conversation will be the last. Do. You. Understand?"
Catra glared daggers at the form from down on the floor, a trickle of blood running from the corner of her mouth. "I understand" she spoke through tightly clenched teeth.
"Good, now get cleaned up, I won't have you skipping meals. You're already weak enough as it is."
And with that, the form vanished. Past Catra spat blood onto the floor and slowly pulled herself up onto the bench, staring into nothingness. Catra moved and sat next to her battered doppleganger, the tears flowing down both their cheeks simultaneously. "She's wrong." She told past Catra, not expecting an answer. "You are NOT weak. You're stronger than she ever was!" She lept to her feet, screaming at the vision if her younger self. "Don't listen to her!" Past Catra slowly stood up, and walked through her current self, leaving the locker room without a word.
And then everything was dark again.
No. She was back where she started. Had she been here the whole time?
Did any of that happen or did she just imagine it?
She took a step only to hear the ear shattering shriek again. She felt dizzy. Where was that coming from?
As it subsided, her dizziness faded with it. She took a few more

steps and with a flash, found herself in the first hallway again. She never broke stride, now determined to see this through.
...
...
"So in short, these power sources are also siphons, in a way." Entrapta and Hordak stood before Micah and Adora, explaining their findings. Hordak picked up where Entrapta left off. "Think of it like the Heart of Etheria, but rather than sapping magic from the planet, it saps it from an individual."
"But more than that, it can also absorb their very essence, more or less creating a digital copy of their personality and likeness!" Entrapta added.
Micah and Adora exchanged troubled looks. Micah spoke first. "So you're saying that they were using people as an energy source, Etherians, and these... Crystals, acted as conduits and storage devices for everything that made them a person?"
"More or less, yes."
"That would explain a lot of the strange happenings and recent sightings. When Shadow Weaver perished, she did so in a violent burst of magical energy. This energy was collected by the original crystal present in this place, along with her image and whatever humanity she may have had left. Make no mistake, she is in fact, still dead. However, her essence is still present in some form. That coupled with the degradation of the tech since the heart was no longer sustaining this place, allowed a sort of 'memory leak' which in turn caused her image and magical energy to seep into the woods, creating anomalous activity."

Adora finally spoke, "But why was she seen so far from here then?"
"Ah, yes well, that would be our fault. Micah, remember the obelisk we stopped at?" Micah nodded. "Well it turns out that our tinkering with them allowed them to act as a sort of signal booster for more than just communications. The magical essence seeping from within the Crystal Castle was able to 'infect' the obelisks in a way, which then was broadcast to the farthest reaches of the woods.
"Ah, so the scout that swears he saw her..."

"Was probably seeing the equivalent of a magical mirage, yes."
Adora grew impatient. "So what happened to Catra? Where is she!? Why are we not saving her already?!"
Entrapta's face grew red and she averted her gaze.
"Well... When I hooked up the second power source, it supercharged the tower. I didn't know that the Crystal Castle already contained one, an inactive one, but functional nonetheless. The boost in power amplified the strength of the magical essences and allowed them to obtain some level of awareness. Not real sentience, but more like you would imagine a hologram, but a magically charged hologram."
"So you're telling me, Catra is trapped somewhere with a hologram Shadow Weaver, and you never even got the chance to hack the security system or put the safety protocols in place?"
Adora felt faint. "I'm sorry..." Entrapta squeaked. Hordak placed a hand upon her shoulder. "You could not have known. What's important now is that we end this. As long as her essence has control of the Castle, Catra is in grave danger. We're all aware of the illusions this place is capable of generating. They are nearly indistinguishable from reality. If we do not act, she could suffer greatly."
Adora felt a fire burning within her. "This place can tap into your memories, use them against you. If Shadow Weaver's essence is in control, it'll know exactly the right buttons to push to send her over the edge. We need to get inside, now!"
The fire within her burned white hot, she felt a familiar presence creeping into her consciousness.
"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

A blinding light filled the clearing, and in Adora's place stood the legendary warrior She-Ra.
She materialized her sword and without a word, approached the front of the Castle. She held her blade aloft, and with a powerful shout, thrust it into the ground. Planting both feet firmly and grasping the sword with both hands, she pulled forward with a scream, a golden aura surrounding her. With an ear splitting crack, a massive fissure opened in the ground, shooting up the wall of the castle. Stone and earth were sent flying, the onlookers

shielded their faces. When the dust settled what remained was a large gaping hole where the castle and ground met. She-Ra turned to her companions and with an expression of stone and determination, her eyes glowing bright blue as if aflame, she spoke in a magisterial tone. "Let's go get my baby."

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(End chapter 2)

Antumbra

Chapter Summary

> Catra's friends scramble to rescue her from the threat of darkness looming over her, as she's forced to face her long time tormentor. Will they be able to reach her in time?

Chapter 3 - Antumbra

Catra steeled herself as she stepped through the curtain. Being forced to relive the most painful times of her life was definitely taking a hard toll on her. She felt physically exhausted from all the crying, and her resolve was weakening. Was her life really this tragic? It hit different seeing it all collected in to a greatest hits of some of her lowest moments. She closed her eyes and took a deep breath, remembering some of the meditation techniques Perfuma had taught her. "You are loved, you are in control." She repeated several times. She sure didn't feel in control right now.

As she opened her eyes, she gasped, taking several steps back, recoiling in fear. The black garnet chamber, Shadow Weaver's sanctum. This is where their conflict had finally come to a head. The air felt oppressively heavy here. She swallowed, approaching the runestone. She tentatively placed a hand upon it. Nothing happened. Of course. It wasn't real, and besides, she wasn't a princess, this was Scorpia's jam now. Scorpia... She felt a pang of regret for the way she had treated her, followed by a sense of longing. She missed her friends. She would do anything to see them right now.
"Hey wildcat."
She whipped around, and suddenly found herself in a prison cell. But Scorpia wasn't there, it was Shadow Weaver in shackles. Her form clearly visible now. With each memory, the shadow cloaking her had faded more and more. She stood looming above the sad looking display. She had forgotten how low she had really been at

this point. She knew what was coming.
"They're sending you to Beast Island" her own voice said flatly from behind her. Shadow Weaver rested her head against the cell wall, defeated, but almost relieved looking.
"When?"
She asked unenthusiastically.
She watched the scene play out, just as she remembered, reciting her own lines emotionlessly alongside the memory of herself.
"Because, you remind me of myself."
"I'm nothing like you!"
She yelled in unison. But she knew she was. Or at least, she had been. Maybe she still was.

She watched as the memory of herself sat down and scooted closer to Shadow Weaver. She silently pleaded to herself, "Come on, don't fall for it. You know she's lying. She's just manipulating you! That's what she does!"
Shadow Weaver placed her hand on the memory's head, stroking her hair. Catra felt a chill run down her spine. It was almost as if she could feel the icy touch herself.
"Get away from her..." She growled. Suddenly, Shadow Weaver stared directly at her. She felt her blood turn to ice.
"Oh, sweet Catra. You don't get a say anymore."
With a flash, she suddenly found herself in Shadow Weaver's place, shackled to the wall. She struggled against the restraints, but to no avail. "Let me go!" She pleadingly shouted.
"Your suffering is only beginning."
Suddenly the world went black.
...
...
She-ra grunted as she pushed a large chunk of stone aside, clearing the hallway for them to proceed. This place was really falling apart.
"Take a left down the next hallway." Entrapta directed, staring intently at her tablet. They marched through the glowing halls, everyone visibly tense. Melog let out a sad yeowl.
"It's okay, we'll find her." Micah reassured them, placing a hand upon their head in comfort. She-Ra stopped in her tracks,

Entrapta walking into her and bouncing off, not even budging the towering woman.
"Ahh!" She cried out as she tumbled to the ground.
Hordak helped her to her feet.
"Why have we stopped?"
She-Ra's eyes narrowed. "There's something there." She whispered, staring into the darkness that engulfed the far end of the hall. The sounds of strange chanting could be heard drifting down the corridor. Without warning, a cluster of shadowy figures bust from the darkness at high speed.
"Here we go!" Warned She-Ra as she readied her blade. Micah quickly prepared a spell and assumed a defensive stance as Hordak shielded Entrapta.

She-Ra slashed the air as the figures approached, sending an arc of light shooting forward. As it struck the figures they immediately dissipated, leaving nothing but a sultry chuckle. Micah hesitated before dispelling his magic. "Come on" demanded She-Ra, "let's just keep moving. Keep your guard up, there's bound to be more tricks ahead."
...
...
Catra's eyes snapped open, she took in her surroundings. She was in a different cell now. Everything was hauntingly white and cold. She felt a lump rise in her throat. No, not here. Anywhere but here.
"You've disappointed me, little sister." The words made her skin crawl.
"But you'll still be of use to me yet. Even one as small and weak as you has a place in service to me."
Her hand shot to the back of her neck, met only with a scar.
She trembled as the force field that acted as the cell door vanished, revealing Horde Prime accompanied by two minions.
"Stay away!" She shrieked, scrambling to the back of the cell. The two minions silently approached and apprehended her, each grabbing an arm firmly. She thrashed and screamed, doing everything she could to escape.

She knew where they were taking her. She could never forget. It was the worst thing she had ever experienced in her life, the pain was indescribable. The feeling of her individuality being sucked away was horrifying. She couldn't go through that again.
She bit one of her captors on the hand, but they didn't even flinch. They dragged her from her cell, kicking and screaming, pleading, anything she could do to not go back there.
"I'm too weak. Everyone was right." Her head slumped in defeat as they dragged her through the barren halls to the purification chamber. Upon seeing the pool, her pupils narrowed, eyes widened, and her heart began beating so rapidly, it felt as if it would explode.
"No! Please! Don't make me go in there!" She begged through tears.
The clones didn't acknowledge her as they dragged her to the edge of the sickly green pool. "Please..."
They hefted her and tossed her forward. She screamed. And as she hit the liquid, she landed with a thud.

Solid ground. She opened her eyes, hearing a voice calling her name. "Catra!" As if from far away.
"Adora? Is that you?" She was on the bridge of Prime's ship.
Here it was. The lowest point in her whole life. She saw herself and Adora near the edge. Heard Prime speaking through her body. "Some creatures, are destined only for destruction." She watched herself fall over the edge, into the inky abyss below.
Adora's image vanished. She remembered. She had died, hadn't she? But Adora had saved her. Brought her back. Took her home. Home...

She thought of Brightmoon, of her, friends, the sacrifices they had made for her.
She thought of Adora, her stupid goofy smile. Of the feeling of her lips when they finally kissed.
"You love me?"
The words echoed.
"You're such an idiot."
No... She couldn't give up. None of this was real. Not anymore. She wasn't that person anymore. She refused to let these

memories define her.
"I'm not weak! I'm not worthless! I am loved. I am valued!" She screamed at whoever was listening.
"Catra!"
She heard her name again.
"You don't control me! I don't need to fit anyone's ideas of what I should be! I'm Catra! And I do whatever the fuck I want!"
Suddenly the bridge was gone, and she was left standing in the void, the only light a glowing purple glyph beneath her.
"Hello... Catra..."
Out of the darkness stepped Shadow Weaver.
...
...
Micah blasted the last of the shadowy forms with a fireball. "How far is it?" He asked hurriedly.
"Not far, just right at the next intersection and at the end of that hall there should be a door." Entrapta replied, checking her tablet to confirm.
Hordak took her hand. "Let's end this."
They rushed down the hall, rounding the corner at the ready, but were met with nothing. A welcome sight at this point.
"There!" She-Ra pointed. A familiar door lie at the end of the corridor. They sprinted to it and stopped.
"Oh, it's one of these."
She-Ra placed her hand upon the cool metallic surface and whispered, "Eternia"
Nothing.
"Eternia!" She repeated loudly.
Nothing.
"Why isn't it working?!" She demanded, punching the door.
"Something doesn't want us in there" Entrapta remarked. "It looks like the power has been diverted."
She-Ra groaned "there's no time for this!"

She took several large steps back. "Stand clear!"
She cautioned.
Everyone exchanged glances before hurrying to the side. She took a running start and with a mighty yell, performed a leaping kick,

striking the door with her heels. The door exploded out of its frame, soaring across the room with a thunderous crash as it came to rest against the opposite wall. She stepped inside the large chamber, the high ceilings towering above her.
"It's a lab!"
Entrapta's voice grew excited. "Look at all this tech!" She hurried to one of the many benches littering the room, covered in long forgotten experiments. Hordak joined her, unable to hide his curiosity. She-Ra approached one of the benches, it was covered in various swords and runestone fragments. Were these... Prototypes?

Her attention was quickly drawn to the large construct at the edge of the room. Micah stepped beside her.
"Is this it?"
"I think so... Entrapta! Snap out of it!" She handed the tech she was doting over to Hordak and dashed to the large console.
"Oh hello there" she said in her bedroom voice.
"What secrets might you contain?"
"Focus, we're here to stop it, not seduce it." Entrapta glanced to Hordak who was stuffing tech into his various pouches. He could handle that, she needed to get to work.
She began typing furiously.
"It looks like she's pretty well integrated into the system, but if I know first ones tech, and I do, there's got to be a back way in."
Her fingers flew across the keys, her focus unwavering as she navigated the archaic system. Her friend needed her, she refused to let her down.
Bingo
"Aha! Got it! I found her!"
Tappa tappa
"And the power source! They're both in the same direction!"
"Where!?" Adora slid in next to Entrapta, scanning the screen.
"There!" She pointed to the map, indicating a large chamber not far from where they were currently.
Suddenly, an alarm sounded and the screen began flashing red.
"WARNING, SECURITY BREECH DETECTED."

"We need to move!" She-Ra shouted to the others. Entrapta ran and grabbed Hordak, who was hastily grabbing all the tech he could stuff into his pouches, pockets, and bag. She-Ra beckoned to Micah and Melog, who joined her and the others as they sprinted from the room. "Hang on Catra, we're coming."
...
...
Catra remained frozen, her and the visage of her tormentor locked in a silent standoff. The glow of the floor beneath them pulsating slowly.
Finally Catra mustered up the nerve to speak.
"How are you even here? I watched you die."
Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Oh, you mean this?"
She waved her hand and the room transformed into a familiar sight. A memory Catra would never forget. A memory forever burned into her mind.
She watched herself helpless behind the magical barrier as the image of Shadow Weaver was consumed by a massive inferno.
"You couldn't even save me."
Catra took a step forward. "Why would I? After everything you did to me. To everyone! No. You made your choice. I thought you had finally decided to do something good with your life for once. But of course you had to accentuate it with more of your mind games." Shadow Weaver's final words echoed through the chamber,
"You're welcome."
And then they were back in the dark room, the purple glow still pulsing.
"Why couldn't you just stay gone? My life is better off without you!"
"You think so? Who raised you? Sheltered you. Trained you. I was the closest thing you ever had to a mother."
"You never loved me! You never even liked me! You ruined me! And just when I'm finally starting to trust people and open myself up, you infect my brain again with your lies and manipulation!"
"Your fragile mentality is your weakness to bear."
"You made me this way!" Catra bellowed.
"Just because I have moments of weakness, that doesn't make

me weak. My friends will always be there to lift me up. They make me feel loved, something you never did, and they never make me feel like I don't belong."
"You would rely on others to support you? What does that say about you?"
"It says that I'm strong enough to admit when I need help. You never asked for help, you just wallowed in your own bitterness until it erased any shred of humanity you had left."
Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed. "I did ask for help once, and I was cast aside. Power, -real- power, must be taken by force."
"You're wrong. Maybe if you were ever a good enough person to make a friend, you would understand."

Shadow Weaver floated across the floor, stopping a few feet from Catra. She leaned in until their faces were only inches apart.
"And what would -you- know of being a good person? You followed in my footsteps. You hurt people just as I did. You think you're any better than me?"
"I do think that, because I am. I was willing to change. I actually felt bad for what I did. But did you? You've probably never apologized to anyone in your life. But you -will- be sorry."
Shadow Weaver stood up straight. "Oh? And you think you can stop me?"

"She won't have to do it alone!"
Shadow Weaver and Catra spun their heads towards the voice, seeing She-Ra step from the shadows, followed by Micah, Entrapta, Hordak, and Melog.
"Adora!"
Catra exclaimed. She ran to join her friends, throwing herself into She-Ra's muscular arms.
"Hey, Catra" she teased, squeezing her tightly. Melog nuzzling her leg. Catra turned and stood with her friends, all of them facing Shadow Weaver. She-Ra stepped forward. "Haven't you caused enough problems? Hurt enough people? I think it's time for you to leave."
"Adora" Shadow Weaver said in the disgustingly sweet way she always addressed her. "Do you really hate me that much? Everything I did, I did for you."

"All you ever did was use me. You were cordial to me, but never kind or warm. Was I even a person to you? Or just another way for you to have control? You only wanted me for my strengths. Mara told me that I'm worth more than what I can give to other people, and it took me a long time to actually accept that about myself. You never made me feel valued beyond what I could do for you."

Micah stepped forward, "You used me for your own twisted, selfish desires. I was just a child! I trusted you, looked up to you even. But Light Spinner died the day Shadow Weaver was born."
"I was trying to save Etheria! I wanted peace, but you were too much of a coward to hold up your end!"
"No, I was strong enough to stand up for what was right. I believe that you wanted to do good at one time, but somewhere along the way you lost that. In the end, it was only about you."

"You hurt Hordak!" Yelled Entrapta, grabbing at his arm.
Shadow Weaver laughed.
"Ahhh, Hordak. Truly the weakest of them all. And a fool at that. How does it feel knowing that you're the reason Prime almost wiped out Etheria? How many people were lost because of you?"
He stepped forward. "I have done unspeakably evil things, untold damage has come from my actions, and I must accept that much of those deeds will forever go unforgiven. But I pay repentance every day, and for those who have graciously granted me a place in the world, I am eternally grateful. But you... You are an abomination. You were so before this whole ordeal. You have no place here, or anywhere. You need to be eradicated once and for all."

He produced a small, cube-like object, one with rounded corners and edges that protruded. He handed the object to She-Ra, who held it with an extended arm.
"This is the end for you. I hope you can find peace in whatever lies for you beyond this place."
She clenched her fist around the device, crushing it in her hand, before letting the dust fall from between her fingers.
Everyone stood still for several beats.

"Was that supposed to do something?" Catra piped up.
She-Ra kept her gaze on Shadow Weaver, "Uhhh... Entrapta? Why didn't it work? Why isn't it working!?"
Shadow Weaver cackled madly. "Oh you really -are- birds of a feather aren't you? Fools! Did you think that it would be that easy? You're forgetting one thing..." The purple glyph beneath them began to pulse faster. "This is MY reality! I AM IN CONTROL!" The glyph glowed blindingly bright as dozens of shadowy figures began pouring in from the darkness.

"To me!" Shouted She-Ra. Her friends formed a circle with their backs to each other.
"What do we do!?"
Yelled Catra as she raised her claws, poised to defend herself.
She-Ra raised her sword.
"We fight!"
"There's too many of them!" Micah interjected.
Entrapta clung to Hordak.
"She's infected the castle too heavily! I don't know what to do! I'm sorry!"
Hordak's eyes lit up, "what about the other device?" Entrapta slapped her forehead.
"Of course! It's still connected outside!" If we can just get to it..."
She-Ra grabbed Catra's arm.
"Let's go!"

They bolted for the exit in a flurry of claws, sword slashes, and spells. Decimating any of the shadow beings who attempted to block their path.
As they reached the door, they tripped over one another, spilling into the hallway. As they attempted to untangle themselves from one another, a shrill shriek filled the air. They all covered their ears in pain.
"What is that?!" Shouted She-Ra.
"I don't know!" Catra shouted back. "It keeps happening!" They looked on in horror as the shadow beasts neared the door.
"We better move!" Micah yelled. But right as the creatures reached the door, it slammed shut. They all stared a moment before scrambling to their feet.

"Just go with it!" She-Ra shouted as they resumed their escape.
"Which way?" She demanded as they approached an intersection.
Entrapta reached for her tablet, her face turning to panic as she realized it was missing.
"Oh no! Oh bad bad bad! I must have dropped my tablet in the frenzy!"
"Forget it! We'll figure it out!"
She shook her head and blinked. She could have sworn she just saw someone up ahead. "Left!" She commanded decisively.
Following anything in this place was probably a bad idea, but she couldn't shake the feeling that this was different. Again, at the next intersection, she was sure she saw the tail end of someone going around the corner. "Right!"
She gave directions as they ran, each time following the faint glimpse of the mystery figure.
"Adora, are you sure you-"
"Just trust me Catra."
Catra looked at She-Ra's face, her eyes focused and determined. She did trust her. She trusted her with her life. On more than one occasion as it would happen. She stuck close and followed.
They ran through the twists and turns of the labyrinthine structure for what felt like an eternity, before finally seeing a faint light.
"There! The exit!" Hordak exclaimed. They made a mad dash towards the light. Towards freedom, only to slam into something solid. They all tumbled to the ground.
"Owwww what the hell!?" Yelled Catra. Hordak placed a hand upon the unseen object and was met with resistance.
"A force field." He informed.
She-Ra roared in frustration. "Really!? We're so close! What-"
Suddenly the hallway darkened, a glowing apparition emerging from the wall. "*Tsk* *tsk* did you -really- think you could escape so easily?" Shadow Weaver laughed. Micah held an offensive spell at the ready, She-Ra raised her sword, Melog turned a bright shade of crimson and hissed, their hair standing on end.
"You cannot win this fight. I am in control."
The party tensed up, ready to strike.

"Y-y-you do not-t belong here, sorceress-s-s"
She-Ra gasped, "That voice..."
Shadow Weaver took a step back. "What is the meaning of this?"
"This is an egregious violation of protocol. You will dis-disassimilate at once."
"Aha I understand now. But you're just an obsolete hunk of first ones junk. If you think you can stop me, hologram, I invite you to try. This is MY domain now!"
"Light Hope..." She-Ra whispered.
Entrapta's eyes widened "The original guardian of the Castle?"
She slapped her forehead, "There must still be fragments of her programming left behind!"

"Look out!" Bellowed Micah as he threw himself in front of the party, casting a shield spell to block the dark flames Shadow Weaver had launched at them. Sweat dripped from his brow as he struggled against the barrage. "We better think of something, or we're all toast!"
"Literally" muttered Catra.
She-Ra looked up, "Light Hope, if that's you, please, we need your help!"
"..... Administrator de-d-detected, activating defense protocols."
Shadow Weaver gasped as dozens of large black spiders began pouring from the vents and doorways, charging directly for her.
"No!" She shrieked, turning her attacks on the new threat. She was, however, quickly overwhelmed and wrapped in a sickly green webbing. "NO!" She cried out in protest.
"Force field, deactivated." Came the voice of Light Hope.
"She-she-she-Ra... Run"
She didn't need to be told twice. They ran hard, beelining for the exit, Shadow Weaver's defiant screams could be heard behind them as she was dragged into the vents, all the spiders going with her.
"Administrator privileges, re-revoked."
They burst forth into the night air, panting and sweating, pausing to catch their breath.

"We're not done yet! Hordak! Your tablet!"
Entrapta snatched the tablet from him and ran to where she had

installed the auxillary power supply. She quickly fumbled with several cables, connecting to the device. As she feverishly typed away, she muttered to herself. "If I can just isolate the signature and reverse the polarity, it should..." An error popped up "Come on! Work! Why won't you work!" Hordak stepped up beside her, onto what she was attempting. "Did you remember to enable write privileges?" He asked with a smirk. She paused and made two simple taps. "I knew I loved you for a reason," She beamed as she drew him into a loving kiss, hitting the key to execute her command without looking.
There was a shockwave, followed by what felt like a major increase in gravity, as if the air had become heavy. Everyone was forced to the ground.

The purple glow began to drain from the castle walls, as if being absorbed by the power source. As the last bit of color left the stone walls, the device sounded a small chime. And then... Silence.
Everyone lie still a moment in anticipation, but all that was left was the pale moonlight and the sound of the wind, whispering through the trees.

"Whaaaaat just happened?" She-Ra inquired, rising to her feet along with the rest of the group. Entrapta reached out and plucked the power source from the tower, it was now glowing a dark purple. "Remember how I said that these babies were used to store energy? Well think of it as me recharging the battery."
"You mean..."
"Precisely" said Hordak. "Shadow Weaver's magical energy and the essence of her being are now all safely contained within."
She-Ra carefully took the device from Entrapta, studying it carefully. "Is it safe?"
"In this state, yes. But remember, the degradation of the previous one was what set off this mess. It's unpredictable at best."

She-Ra sighed and relaxed her body. She felt the presence departing from her as she was once again her regular old self. She was Adora once more. She slowly approached Catra.
"Well. This is her." Catra stared at the glowing shape.

"No, it's not. This is the worst parts of her. This is nothing but memories and magic."
Adora stood still, the wind blowing her hair gently. "Do you think... She could have changed? If she was still here do you think we could have got through to her? Or was she too far gone?" Catra placed a hand on the device. "I'd like to think that with enough love and support, anyone can change." She looked to Hordak and Entrapta, who were geeking out over all the new tech Hordak had managed to recover.
"I think she was just never as lucky as us. She never had friends like we do. Maybe that's her own fault, but it's still sad.'
Adora placed a hand atop Catra's.
"So, what do we do with it?"
Catra took the device and gave it one final look, before opening her fingers and letting it fall to the ground. She raised a foot and stomped on it with all her might, reducing it to nothing more than dust and memories.

The two stared silently at the mess for a brief moment.
"You know what's funny, Adora? One of the last things she said to me was that she was proud of me. She said it was too late for her, but for me, it was just the beginning."
Adora squeezed Catra's hand gently. "I don't think it was too late for her, she just decided that it was. But she was right about one thing.'
"What's that?"
"It was just the beginning for you, and now we get to make our own path, our own story. And we get to do it together."
"You, are -so- corny." Catra teased, pulling Adora into a passionate kiss as the daylight moon broke through the tops of the trees, casting a warm light upon them.

The moment was broken by a loud shout.
"SWIFT WIND TO THE RESCUE"
They spun just in time to see the winged unicorn land to a grinding halt, feet from them.
"Oh whaaaat? Did I miss it? Where's the action?"
Adora and Catra broke into laughter. "It's all good Swifty. Everyone's safe."

Glimmer and Bow came running over. "Adora!" Glimmer hollered, throwing herself into an embrace with her friend.
"Swift Wind told us you were in trouble, something about your spiritual bond and that we needed to find you."
"Glimmer, relax, it's all taken care of. We're all going to be okay."
It was then that glimmer noticed everyone else. "What the -hell- happened? Why is my dad and everyone else here?"
"I'll explain it all during breakfast, because MAN could I eat right now."
"See? I told you. I TOLD you to be safe." Catra laughed. "Like this girl could ever do that. When has she ever backed down from danger?" She jested, giving Adora a soft punch on the arm. Adora giggled and grabbed Catra in a headlock, tousling her hair. "You're just lucky I'm so reckless!"
"More like lucky you're so clumsy!"
She grabbed Adora around the waist and pulled her to the ground, laughing.
Glimmer rolled her eyes. "These two will never grow up." She groaned. Bow just shrugged as the girls wrestled about on the ground giggling, Swift Wind egging them on. "Get her Adora! Full Nelson! Get her!" Glimmer chuckled. As the moon rose in the sky, it shone upon the Crystal Castle, which had fallen dark for the final time.
...
...
Adora awoke to the morning light hitting her face. She stirred before groaning loudly. "Whyyyy-hyyyy-hyyyy?"
She lazily rolled from bed and trudged to the vanity. Her eyes barely open. She swiped her jacket from where it hung and stuffed her arms through the sleeves. She pulled a brush through her hair a few times until it was satisfactorily less messy. She reached back to tie up her hair, but paused to give her mirror self a side eye. Maybe she'd just wear it down today, she thought. It looked strangely nice to her.
"Hey Catra do you-" she turned to find the bed empty.
"Hmm?"
She stepped out on to the balcony and took a deep breath of the

fresh air. The warm morning light felt good against her face. She glanced down and saw Catra, sitting beneath her favorite tree.

She hastily made her way down to the courtyard doors, receiving salutes from the guards. "Up top!" She called, raising a hand in the air. The guard cocked her head in confusion.
"Come on, don't leave me hanging!" The guard gave a light palm to palm slap. "Woo! Yeah!" Adora cheered as she flung the courtyard doors open and skipped out into the garden. As she approached the tree, she saw Catra sitting cross legged, eyes closed. Across from her sat Perfuma in the same position. Catra's ear twitched, and before Adora could speak, Catra greeted her without even opening her eyes.
"Heyyy Adooorrraaaa!" She said happily, the corners of her mouth turning up slightly. Perfuma opened one eye and waved at Adora, receiving a wave in kind.
"I think this is a good place to stop for the day Catra, if that's okay with you?" Perfuma said gently.
"Yeah it's good. I feel good. Thank you, Perfuma. I'll see you in a few days?"
"Oh no, you'll see me today! We're all going to Mystacor for a weekend getaway, and you should definitely come. Both of you." Catra smiled. "I wouldn't miss it for anything."

The sounds of excited chatter could be heard growing louder as the rest of the princess could be seen approaching from across the garden. Upon seeing the trio, Scorpia headed straight for them and scooped all three up in a massive crushing hug.
"There's my favorite girls!"
She set them down and placed a pincer on Catra's shoulder.
"How's it hanging wildcat?" She said with a wink.
"Better every day. It's good to see you."
"You might not say that when I clobber you at ice ball later." Catra guffawed. "In your dreams pinchy."
The rest of the group caught up and they all greeted each other, laughing and sharing stories. Catra took Adora's hand and smiled. For the first time in her life, she truly knew who she was. And she

loved it. And she. Was. Killing it.
✨💕✨

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